

TIOBE PROGRAMMING COMMUNITY INDEX

TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Ratings calculated from skilled engineers, training courses, and third-party vendors using search-engine hit counts across Google, Amazon, Wikipedia, Bing, and 20+ other sites.

Source: tiobe.com • Captured April 2026



Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Full top-20 ranking with March 2026 position, prior-year position, rating, and year-over-year change.

RANK	PREV	LANGUAGE	RATING	YOY CHANGE
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%



Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 -- The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

Languages with the most dramatic year-over-year rank changes.

▲ Biggest Gainers			▼ Biggest Losers		
Perl	24	→ 11	Go	7	→ 16
R	16	→ 9	C++	2	→ 3
Swift	26	→ 20	Java	3	→ 4
C	4	→ 2	PHP	13	→ 18
Assembly	17	→ 17 (+6.4%)	Fortran	11	→ 13



From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Rank positions across four decades. C is the only language to remain in the top 2 at every measurement point.

LANGUAGE	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	—	—
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	—	—
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	—	—	—
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	—	—
Go	10	11	60	16	—	—	—	—	—
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2



Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times -- More Than Any Other Language

TIOBE "Programming Language of the Year" winners from 2016 to 2025. The award goes to the language with the largest gain in ratings during a calendar year.

2025 C#	2024 Python	2023 C#	2022 C++	2021 Python
2020 Python	2019 C	2018 Python	2017 N/A	2016 Go



The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Key findings and actionable implications for technology decision-makers.

- **Python dominates but is losing ground.** At 21.25%, Python leads by a wide margin, yet its -2.59 percentage point YoY decline is the largest drop among the top 5. Monitor whether this is a correction or a trend.
- **C's resurgence signals systems-language demand.** C gained +2.02 points and climbed from 4th to 2nd. Low-level performance remains critical for infrastructure and embedded teams.
- **Legacy languages show surprising resilience.** Perl jumped from 24th to 11th (+1.05%), R rose from 16th to 9th (+0.94%), and Fortran remains in the top 15. Scientific and data communities are sticky.
- **Go suffers its sharpest decline.** Go fell from 7th to 16th, losing 1.49 percentage points -- the largest absolute drop in the top 20. Rust (14th, +0.09%) may be displacing it in systems programming.
- **Concentration risk is real.** Python, C, C++, and Java together account for 48.97% of total TIOBE ratings. Diversifying hiring and training across emerging languages reduces lock-in.

